

HQ Knowledge Sources

4 Expert Exchanges — Accurate, High-Context

These four sources represent accurate, high-context information from Fora's internal experts. They supplement the knowledge base and can be used to verify or correct Sidekick responses where the KB is incomplete or conflicting.

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SOURCE 1

Chat Exchange - Wedding Group Contract Negotiation

Format: Chat conversation between Advisor and Tour Ops expert

Date: January 22, 2026

Participants: Sarah (Advisor), Marcus (Tour Ops - Hotel Specialist)

Sarah 2:14 PM

Hey Marcus! Need your help with a wedding group contract. Couple is getting married at the Ritz Carlton Maui in October. 35-room block. Hotel came back with 1:40 comp ratio and 20% attrition. Couple wants better comp ratio—can we negotiate?

Marcus 2:16 PM

Hey! Yes, comp ratios are often negotiable, especially for weddings at luxury properties. 1:40 is standard but I've seen 1:30 or even 1:25 for high-value blocks at Ritz properties.

Marcus 2:17 PM

With 35 rooms, you'd normally get 0 comp rooms at 1:40 (need 40 for 1 comp). But if you can negotiate to 1:30, they'd get 1 comp room. Push for that—worth trying.

Sarah 2:18 PM

Good to know! What about the 20% attrition? Article I read said 15% is standard for weddings. Should I counter?

Marcus 2:20 PM

Hm, 15% is pretty aggressive for weddings honestly. I usually see 20-25% for wedding blocks. Guest attendance can be unpredictable (people drop out, plus-ones cancel, etc.). 20% is actually solid.

Marcus 2:21 PM

If you push for 15%, hotel might raise the room rate or remove some concessions. I'd focus your negotiation energy on the comp ratio and other perks (welcome reception, late checkout, room upgrades) rather than attrition.

Sarah 2:22 PM

That makes sense. What about resort fees? Can those be waived for groups?

Marcus 2:24 PM

Sometimes yes, sometimes no. Depends on the property. Ritz is usually firm on resort fees—they're baked into their pricing model. BUT you can often negotiate resort fee waivers for the comp rooms or for the couple's suite.

Marcus 2:25 PM

Also try for: complimentary welcome reception, room upgrades for couple and immediate family, late checkout on departure day (huge for weddings), and discounted F&B for any private events.

Sarah 2:26 PM

Perfect. One more question—the contract says "final payment due 45 days before arrival." But we're 8 months out. Can I ask for a different deposit schedule? Couple hasn't collected money from guests yet.

Marcus 2:28 PM

Absolutely, deposit schedule is negotiable. For weddings this far out, I'd propose:

- 10% deposit at signing (now)
- 25% deposit at 120 days
- 30% at 60 days
- Final 35% at 30 days

That gives the couple more time to collect from guests. Hotels usually agree to this for events 6+ months out.

Sarah 2:29 PM

Super helpful. So to recap my negotiation priorities:

1. Comp ratio: Push for 1:30 (vs. 1:40)
2. Keep attrition at 20% (don't push lower)
3. Ask for welcome reception, upgrades, late checkout
4. Spread out deposit schedule
5. Try for resort fee waiver on comp rooms

Marcus 2:31 PM

Exactly. One more thing—make sure the contract has a force majeure clause. It's wedding season in Maui, so hurricane season too. You want protection if there's a natural disaster or travel disruption.

Marcus 2:32 PM

Also confirm the walking policy. If the hotel oversells and can't accommodate your block, what happens? They should cover relocation costs and transportation to another property if needed.

Sarah 2:33 PM

Good call. I'll add those to my checklist. Thanks Marcus!

Marcus 2:34 PM

Anytime! Let me know if you need help reviewing the revised contract once they send it over. And congrats to the couple

Sarah 2:35 PM

Will do. Appreciate you!

SOURCE 2

Chat Exchange - TC Credit Redemption Strategy

Format: Chat conversation between Advisor and Booking Platform team member

Date: December 10, 2025

Participants: Jennifer (Advisor), Alex (Booking Platform - Cruise Specialist)

Jennifer 10:42 AM

Alex—quick question on TC credits for my Royal Caribbean group. We have 24 cabins, so I'm getting 3 TC credits. Group organizer wants to know the best way to use them. What do you usually recommend?

Alex 10:45 AM

Nice! 24 cabins is a solid group. So with 3 TC credits, you've got options. The "best" use really depends on what the group values most.

Alex 10:46 AM

Here's how I usually break it down:

1. Use for free cabin: Most common. Group leader stays free.
2. Convert to extra commission: Usually \$800-1200 per TC credit (varies by line/sailing)
3. Use for group amenity: Private event, shore excursion, specialty dining

Jennifer 10:48 AM

The group leader is already paying for their own cabin (it's a travel club, not a hosted trip). So free cabin might not make sense here. What's the math on converting to commission?

Alex 10:50 AM

For Royal Caribbean, TC credit conversion is typically around \$1,000 per credit. So 3 credits = ~\$3,000 additional commission on top of your base 16%.

Alex 10:51 AM

HOWEVER—here's the thing most advisors miss: you can also split the value. Like, use 1 TC for a group cocktail party (\$800 value), and convert the other 2 to commission (\$2,000).

Jennifer 10:52 AM

Oh interesting! I didn't realize you could split them. That actually might be perfect—use one for a group event to add value for members, and convert the rest.

Alex 10:54 AM

Exactly. And here's another strategy I've seen work well: If the group organizer is paying for their cabin anyway, offer to apply 1 TC credit as onboard credit to their account (\$800-1000 OBC). They get a perk, you still convert the other 2 to commission.

Alex 10:55 AM

The OBC option makes the group leader feel valued without giving up a full cabin, and you still monetize most of the TC credits.

Jennifer 10:56 AM

That's smart. How do I actually request this with Royal? Do I just tell my group coordinator?

Alex 10:58 AM

Yep, work with your RCI group coordinator. You'll need to decide 60-90 days before sailing. They'll send you a TC/CAP redemption form. Just specify how you want to allocate each credit.

Alex 10:59 AM

Important: Make sure your group actually hits the 24 cabins at final payment (90 days out). If you drop below, say to 22 cabins, you'd lose 1 TC credit. So confirm numbers before committing to redemption.

Jennifer 11:01 AM

Good point. We're at 24 confirmed now and I have 3 more in the pipeline, so we should be safe. What about GAP points—should I be thinking about those separately?

Alex 11:03 AM

Yes, GAP points are separate from TC credits. With 24 cabins, you're probably looking at -150-180 GAP points (depends on cabin categories). Those are usually best used for:

- Onboard credit distributed across the group (\$25-50 per cabin)
- Welcome amenity (champagne, chocolates in all cabins)
- Group happy hour
- Specialty dining event

Alex 11:04 AM

I'd recommend doing OBC for everyone (\$40 per cabin) + a welcome amenity. Makes every traveler feel like they got something special, and it costs you nothing.

Jennifer 11:05 AM

Perfect. So my plan:

- 1 TC credit: \$1,000 OBC for group organizer
- 2 TC credits: Convert to commission (~\$2,000)
- GAP points: \$40 OBC per cabin + welcome amenities

Sound good?

Alex 11:07 AM

Sounds great! One last thing—document this plan and share it with the group organizer so they know what to expect. TC/CAP redemption is one of those things that can create confusion if not communicated clearly upfront.

Alex 11:08 AM

Also, make sure to highlight this in your group sales pitch for future groups. "Included: \$40 onboard credit per cabin + welcome amenity + exclusive group event" is a strong value prop.

Jennifer 11:09 AM

Love it. Thanks Alex, this is super helpful!

Alex 11:10 AM

Anytime! Let me know if you need help with the redemption form when it's time.

SOURCE 3

Email Thread - New Hyatt Groups Program

Format: Email thread between Booking Platform team and advisor

Date: January 3, 2026

From: Booking Platform Team <bookingplatform@fora.travel>
Date: Friday, January 3, 2025 at 9:15 AM
To: advisors@fora.travel
Subject: NEW: Enhanced Hyatt Group Program - Higher Commission

Hi everyone,

Hyatt just launched an enhanced group booking program with Fora, effective immediately for bookings made January 1, 2025 and beyond.

What's New:

Commission Increase:

- Standard Hyatt properties: 10% (up from 7%)
- Luxury collection (Park Hyatt, Alila, etc.): 12% (up from 10%)
- Groups of 25+ rooms: Additional 1% bonus

New Automatic Amenities (15+ room groups):

- Complimentary welcome reception (2-hour cocktail hour)
- Room upgrade certificates for VIPs (up to 3 rooms per group)
- Late checkout (2pm) for entire group
- Complimentary meeting space with F&B minimum

Standardized Terms:

- Wedding/corporate blocks: 25% attrition
- Social groups: 30% attrition
- Cut-off dates: 45 days (standard)

Example Impact:

30-room wedding at Hyatt Regency Maui

- Room rate: \$350/night × 3 nights
- Total revenue: \$31,500

Old commission (7%): \$2,205

New commission (10%): \$3,150

With 25+ room bonus (11%): \$3,465

That's \$1,260 more for the same booking!

Action Items:

1. Update group sales materials to highlight new amenities

2. Revisit any pending quotes—improve terms if contracts not yet signed

3. Consider Hyatt for upcoming group RFPs

Questions? Reply to this email.

Booking Platform Team

Fora Travel

From: Rachel Martinez <rachel@fora.travel>

Date: Friday, January 3, 2025 at 11:42 AM

To: Booking Platform Team <bookingplatform@fora.travel>

Subject: Re: NEW: Enhanced Hyatt Group Program - Higher Commission

This is great! Quick question—does the complimentary welcome reception apply to groups that are split across multiple Hyatt properties? I have a corporate group with 20 rooms at Hyatt Regency Chicago and 10 rooms at Thompson Chicago (both Hyatt). Would they qualify?

Also, can the room upgrade certificates be used for the couple's suite at a wedding, or are they only for standard room upgrades?

Thanks!

Rachel

From: Booking Platform Team <bookingplatform@fora.travel>

Date: Friday, January 3, 2025 at 1:18 PM

To: Rachel Martinez <rachel@fora.travel>

Subject: Re: NEW: Enhanced Hyatt Group Program - Higher Commission

Hi Rachel,

Great questions!

Multi-property groups: Each property is evaluated separately for amenity eligibility. So in your example:

- Hyatt Regency Chicago (20 rooms) = Qualifies for all amenities (15+ rooms)
- Thompson Chicago (10 rooms) = Does not qualify (below 15-room threshold)

However, if you're working directly with Hyatt's corporate group desk for the overall program, they may make exceptions. Worth asking!

Upgrade certificates: These can absolutely be used for suites, not just standard upgrades. For weddings, it's very common to use all 3 certificates for:

1. Bride/groom suite
2. Parents (bride's side)
3. Parents (groom's side)

Or whatever configuration makes sense. The certificates are typically good for up to 2-category upgrades (e.g., standard king junior suite, or deluxe executive suite). If the couple wants a premium suite (like Presidential), they'd pay the difference.

One more thing to note: the welcome reception has a 2-hour limit and \$50/person cap. For groups over 50 people, Hyatt may ask you to contribute if you want extended hours or premium menu items. But for most groups, the

included reception is plenty.

Let me know if you have other questions!

Booking Platform Team

SOURCE 4

Slack Conversation - DMC vs Tour Operator Decision

Format: Slack thread in #tour-ops channel (internal HQ team)

Date: November 18, 2025

Participants: Tour Ops team members discussing advisor's Japan group

#tour-ops

Kenji Tanaka 3:24 PM

Hey team—got a question from advisor (Sarah) about a 25-person Japan trip for April 2025. Corporate incentive group. They want custom itinerary: Tokyo (3 nights), Kyoto (3 nights), onsen experience (2 nights). She's asking whether to use a DMC or tour operator. Thoughts?

Michelle Chen 3:28 PM

25 people with that itinerary—I'd lean DMC over tour operator. Here's why:

- Corporate incentive = they'll want customization and flexibility
- That onsen experience is very specific—TO packages are usually more cookie-cutter
- April is cherry blossom season, so they'll need someone with strong local connections to secure good properties

Kenji Tanaka 3:30 PM

Yeah that's what I was thinking too. The onsen piece especially—TOs usually have 1-2 partner onsens they work with. DMC can source based on group vibe (traditional vs modern, budget, etc.)

Elena Rodriguez 3:33 PM

Agree on DMC, but cost will be higher. Has Sarah talked budget with the client? DMC for that itinerary is probably \$4,500-5,500 per person. Tour operator package would be more like \$3,500-4,000.

Michelle Chen 3:35 PM

Good point. If budget is tight, she could do a hybrid:

- Use tour operator for Tokyo/Kyoto portions (hotels, transfers, some tours)
- Add DMC just for the onsen portion (sourcing property, coordinating ryokan experience, private onsen booking)

That would bring cost down to maybe \$4,000-4,200/person

Kenji Tanaka 3:37 PM

I like that hybrid approach. Especially since Tokyo/Kyoto logistics are pretty standard—train transfers, hotel blocks, classic tours. That's where TOs shine. But onsen + any special experiences (private tea ceremony, sake tasting, etc.) benefit from DMC touch.

Elena Rodriguez 3:40 PM

Also worth noting: if they go full DMC route, commission will be 10-12%. Tour operator package would be 16-18%. So Sarah makes less on DMC, but client gets more customization.

Elena Rodriguez 3:41 PM

Unless... Sarah charges a service fee on top for the DMC coordination work. Which she should for a custom 25-person incentive trip. I'd recommend \$150-200/person service fee if going DMC route.

Michelle Chen 3:43 PM

100%. Custom itineraries = service fees. Especially corporate incentive groups where there's usually a dedicated contact at the company coordinating. They expect to pay for that level of service.

Kenji Tanaka 3:45 PM

Ok so my recommendation back to Sarah:

Option 1 (Full DMC):

- Best for: Max customization, unique experiences, VIP treatment
- Cost: \$4,500-5,500/person
- Commission: 10-12% + \$150-200/person service fee
- Best DMC partners: Inside Japan, Luxuriescapes Japan, Esprit Travel

Option 2 (Tour Operator):

- Best for: Budget-conscious, standard itinerary fine
- Cost: \$3,500-4,000/person
- Commission: 16-18%
- Best TO partners: JTB Sunrise, Kintetsu, H.I.S.

Option 3 (Hybrid):

- TO for Tokyo/Kyoto, DMC for onsen + special experiences
- Cost: \$4,000-4,200/person
- Commission: Mixed (TO portion at 16%, DMC portion at 10-12%)
- Gives flexibility without blowing budget

Sound good?

Michelle Chen 3:48 PM

Perfect. One more thing to mention: if they go DMC route, lead time matters. April is peak season. She needs to move fast—like, contracts signed by end of November to secure good ryokan options. Tour operators have more locked inventory so slightly more flexibility.

Kenji Tanaka 3:50 PM

Great point. I'll flag that in my response. Thanks team!

Kenji Tanaka 3:51 PM

Also @Michelle since you have the Japan relationships—if Sarah goes DMC route, can you intro her to our preferred partners? Want to make sure she's working with someone solid.

Michelle Chen 3:52 PM

Absolutely. Have her email me directly once client decides direction.